Supporting Accessibility at Shelters

Guidance for workers at shelters on providing accessible services to all clients

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: Shelter Shift Supervisors, Disaster Disability Integration, Disaster Health Services

Considerations

- We provide accessible services to all clients including people with disabilities and other access and functional needs.
- We prioritize making necessary accommodations and modifications to make all areas and services of the shelter accessible.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
    - Shelter Operations

What to do

- Ask clients if there is anything specific that Red Cross can do to support them while they are staying at the shelter.
    - Do not assume what help is needed.

- Consult with Disaster Disability Integration and Disaster Health Services to for guidance to determine the appropriate accommodation or modification to meet client accessibility needs.
- Make sure the areas being used for client services are accessible to all clients and workers and be sure the following areas are accessible to all clients and workers:
    - Shelter parking and drop-off areas
    - Entrances and exits
    - Restrooms and showers
    - Routes within the shelter
    - Sleeping areas
    - Feeding areas
    - Supply distribution areas

- Inform HQ Sheltering Manager if modifications are needed. This might include ramps, railing, or additional lighting.
    - Make sure clients who require electrical power for medical equipment have access and facilitate use if needed.

- When needed, arrange for mobility equipment.
    - Request equipment from Disaster Health Services or Fulfillment if a client needs a wheelchair, walker, or other mobility support.

- Post accessible signage throughout the shelter.
    - Post universal signage and large-print signage for those who are visually impaired
    - Use multiple language signage and signs with images/graphics when possible
    - Coordinate with DRO Headquarters when signage in Braille or other languages is necessary

- Supporting clients whose primary language is not English.
    - Ensure announcements and posted information are available in all primary languages of clients at the shelter.
    - Share information in multiple languages, according to the needs of the clients and staff

    - If phone-based or in-person spoken language translation services are needed, submit the request to the Sheltering Activity Manager
- Supporting clients who may have difficulty reading.
    - Recruit volunteers to read information for clients who can't read.
    - Make large-print signs in at least 18-point font with high contrast black text on white background for clients with reduced vision.

- Supporting clients who are deaf or hard of hearing.
    - Activate the closed captioning function on all televisions.
    - Make audio announcements available in writing out or by using sign language interpreters when needed.
    - Offer Video Relay Services for client needing to make calls.
    - For more, see the Video Relay Services for Deaf or Hard of Hearing clients Job Tool
    - Provide access to sign language interpreters and/or Video Remote Interpreting services for Deaf or Hard of Hearing clients who use sign language.

Related Articles

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Sharing Key Information Between the Shelter and the HQ Sheltering Manager
Types of information and methods of communication shared between shelters and DRO headquarters.

Gather and Share Essential Information to Support the Initiation of Sheltering